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My Money Lives in Two Countries. So Does My Anxiety.

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What does it cost to be the one who “made it”? A lyrical, unflinching look at Black tax, money guilt, and emotional debt.

> *You can't build a future when your paycheck has a boarding pass. This is what Black tax looks like in the diaspora: love, guilt, sacrifice, and slow-burning exhaustion.*

The Exchange Rate Between Guilt and Giving

My salary arrives in dollars. But before I can breathe, I’m converting it into four other things: rent, groceries, guilt, and remittances.

The money lands in one country but is expected to perform miracles in another. There’s always something urgent: a hospital bill, a school fee, a rent top-up. Sometimes it’s unspoken. Sometimes it’s expected before it’s even requested. Sometimes the ask comes with a thank you already included.

And I always feel like I’m behind. Not because I’m reckless, but because I’m split. Because I live in a high-cost country, but carry the needs of a low-trust economy on my back. Because I’m the one who “made it.” Whatever that means.

And it’s not always diaspora. Even when I lived at home, the guilt was constant – the quiet obligation to give to the church, sponsor a youth program, help “just this once” with the neighborhood fundraiser. You don’t say no to your community. You don’t walk past a need. But what if your own needs are whispering too?

Is Black Tax a Burden Or A Curse?

What They Don’t Tell You About “Making It”

Whether you’re the one who left or the one who stayed – if you’re Black, you know this: to be seen as successful is to be seen as responsible for everyone else.

And it's not just about being the first. Sometimes it’s about being visible at all. You got a job, any job? You're doing well. You posted a photo in front of a building with central air? You must

be rich. Even when your own dreams feel out of reach – when you're still living paycheck to borrowed paycheck, someone sees you and thinks: this one has made it.

When you're the first in your family or community to "make it" abroad, in a big city, with a stable job or a degree – you don't get a blueprint. You get a silent agreement.

You will help. You will send money. You will answer every call that begins with "I didn't want to bother you but…" and ends with your wallet open. You will keep giving, even when you're scraping your own survival. And you'll smile while doing it.

This is Black tax.

It doesn't matter whether you live in Lagos or London, Atlanta or Accra. Black tax follows us across borders. It's not a bill in the mail. It's a memory in your blood. A whisper that says: Don't forget who fed you. Don't forget where you come from.

But what if where you come from is swallowing you whole?

Black tax isn't inherently bad. It comes from love, community, and reciprocity. But when there's no ceiling, no boundary, no plan – it becomes a drain. A fracture. A silent burnout that erodes your future while you hold up someone else's present.

The Boundaries That Never Hold

I've tried to set boundaries.

I've said, "I can't help this month." And then sent something anyway.

I've promised myself I would save. That I would invest. That I would finally buy that thing I've been wanting. But I don't. Because someone back home needs help. And I can't imagine them thinking I'm selfish.

The problem with boundaries, especially when you're Black and communal, is that they're often mistaken for pride. Or punishment. Or proof that you've changed.

No one taught us how to draw lines. Only how to stretch.

And so every month becomes a test of your love. Not your capacity. Not your stability. Just your willingness to bleed a little more.

Here's what that does to your nervous system: you become hyper-vigilant. Every phone call feels like a countdown. Every bank notification, a new panic. You flinch when your name shows up in a group chat. You start avoiding calls — not because you don't care, but because you're already in pieces.

It’s not that you don’t want to help. It’s that no one ever asked what it costs you.

It’s hard to admit, but I’ve felt safer giving than saying no — because generosity, even when unsustainable, feels better than guilt. And when you’ve grown up around survival, guilt is a luxury you’re expected to afford.

Listen to this TEDx talk about boundaries and burnout

The Guilt of Having Plans

I’ve had days where I looked at my account and thought, “This could be my savings.” But then I hear, “My rent is due.”

I’ve paused therapy because I needed to cover school fees.

I’ve skipped groceries to top up someone else’s electricity.

This is what they don’t post in the #diasporalife reels. That the cost of living in two countries is not just financial — it’s psychological. It’s spiritual. It’s the fatigue of being the emergency plan for an entire network.

When Helping Breaks You

You don’t have to look far for examples of what this strain can do. Black and minority entrepreneurs across history have tried to carry their people and lost everything in the process.

Take Jesse Binga, Chicago’s first Black banker. He refused to foreclose on Black churches during the Great Depression — even as it sank his own bank.

Or Annie Turnbo Malone, the beauty mogul who employed thousands. A bitter divorce, endless requests, and lawsuits stripped her empire bare.

And Samuel B. Fuller, once one of America’s richest Black businessmen. His community-first approach was noble, but legal troubles and boycotts crushed his legacy.

We love to say “we rise by lifting others.” But no one tells you what happens when the lifting breaks your back.

The Illusion of Western Wealth

“Just send a little.” “It’s only $100.”

They don’t know that $100 here is transit fare, phone bill, a quarter of rent. They see you earning in foreign currency and think you’re thriving. But they don’t see you counting coins at the self-checkout. They don’t see you skipping dentist appointments, ignoring cracked shoes,

or choosing between Wi-Fi and groceries. They don’t know you’ve delayed therapy for the third month in a row because the insurance deductible is too steep.

They hear "dollars" and assume abundance. They don’t hear the silence of a fridge light that doesn’t come on. They don’t feel the isolation of being everyone's emergency contact and no one’s priority.

There’s a dangerous illusion that once you cross borders or enter a higher-income bracket, you’re immune to struggle. But struggle just changes currency.

You look rich in Naira. But your bank app tells another story.

You look blessed online. But you’re bargaining with your own well-being behind the screen.

And there’s no explaining that. Because in their eyes, you have made it.

What I’m Learning to Say (Softly, but Firmly)

I’m learning to say:

- “Not this month.”

- “I’ll help, but here’s my limit.”

- “I need to take care of myself, too.”

These words feel small in my mouth. Fragile. Like apologies. But they are not.

They are declarations. Of self-worth. Of capacity. Of honest math.

Because no one ever taught me that giving has a rhythm. That helping has seasons. That generosity without boundary is not love — it’s leakage.

It took me years to understand that being a safe place for others doesn’t mean being a bottomless one. That I could be caring and cautious. That I could say no and still be kind.

Boundaries are not brick walls. They are breathing room. And when I say no now, it is not rejection – it is restoration. Of my energy. Of my ability to give again, when I can, and how I choose.

I am still generous. But I’m also healing. And sometimes healing looks like closing your hand long enough to refill it — so when you open it again, it’s a choice, not a cry for help in disguise.

The Math Isn’t Mathing, and Neither Is the Martyrdom

If your money lives in two countries, your anxiety probably lives in three.

Because it's not just about money. It’s about pressure. Expectation. And the quiet grief of never choosing yourself.

You start the month with a plan. A spreadsheet. A dream of finally keeping something for yourself. But then the phone rings. The text comes. The group chat lights up.

You give again. You shrink again. You survive – barely.

But surviving is not the same as thriving. And being needed is not the same as being cared for.

So here’s what I’m reminding myself, and maybe you too:

Your worth is not in your wire transfers. Your loyalty is not measured by how little you keep. And your love doesn’t have to be proven with receipts.

You are allowed to pause. To breathe. To choose.

Because no one deserves to go broke just trying to be good.

Say that out loud. Say it in your mother tongue. Say it in dollars. Say it with your chest.

But say it.

Why This Story Lives Here

Makolaa exists to hold space for stories like this — stories about nuance, pressure, and the financial truths we don’t often say aloud. Because wealth isn’t just about money. It’s about boundaries, healing, and freedom too.

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